Show Up to Defend the Constitution

A Roadmap for Defending the Constitution and Empowering the People

“The Constitution is worth saving, the rule of law is worth saving, democracy is worth saving — but these things can and will be lost if everyone waits around for someone else.”

— Timothy Snyder

Free civic organizing toolkit for neighborhood gatherings.

How This Deck Is Organized

An roadmap for the resistance movement covering why, how, and what.

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Show up. Create a crisis plan together. Build a local network to empower the people.

Why This Movement

Let's organize local networks to defend the Constitution and reclaim the power of the people.

Over 8 Million Showed Up

On March 28, 2026, at 3,300 events in all 50 states.

Now imagine if those 8 million formed local networks with sustained participation — nameless, leaderless, self-organized — like what happened in Minneapolis.

Minneapolis Showed the Way

Neighbors who barely knew each other built something durable to protect each other.

No leaders required. No permission needed. Just love and care — and the will to show up.

Some started calling this “neighborism.”

Two Paths. One Preparation.

A sudden crisis — courts defied, election stolen, martial law declared — that demands action in hours.

Or slow erosion: press attacked, prosecutors weaponized.

Both require organized people who already know and trust each other.

The Will of the People

The importance of building a powerful, local network.

Congress has some tools to stop a constitutional breakdown initiated by the federal government. It can terminate emergency declarations, restrict the Insurrection Act, withhold military funding, and ultimately impeach. **But laws are only as strong as the will to enforce them.**

Political scientist Erica Chenoweth studied resistance campaigns across more than a century and found that nonviolent campaigns succeed by broadening the base of resistance and raising the costs to opponents of maintaining the status quo.

No government has survived **sustained participation by 3.5% of the population** — in the US, that's about 11 million people. Over 8 million participated in No Kings rallies across all fifty states.

The key phrase is "sustained participation."

Political Hobbyism vs Real Organizing

Politics is about building power, not just expressing values.

4 in 5 **people who spend 2+ hrs/day on politics spend zero minutes on actual organizing.**

— Eitan Hersh, *Politics Is for Power*

Political Hobbyism — What Most of Us Do

Consume & react. Scroll news, share outrage, post hot takes. Emotional engagement is not political power — it changes nothing on the ground.

Perform publicly. Signal views to people who already agree. This is identity work, not organizing.

Wait for a leader. Donate to campaigns but keep a distance day-to-day. Depend on charisma rather than relationships you build yourself.

Real Organizing According to Hersh

Acquire power, not just express values. Organizing is the work of building the capacity to make people in power do things they otherwise wouldn't.

Build relationships with people who don't already agree. Real organizing means going to where persuadable people are and building trust over time.

Show up between crises, not just during them. The organizer who appears only when things are urgent has no relationships to activate. Power is built slowly.

"That no one is relying on you is a great sign that what you're doing is a shallow hobby." — Eitan Hersh

Minneapolis Responded to a Crisis

The people created a nameless, leaderless, self-organized network that is the foundation for long-term resistance and empowerment.

They Showed Up

- Brought food to neighbors afraid to leave home
- Escorted children to school safely
- Stood watch outside neighbors' homes through the night

They Watched with Care

- Sent encrypted alerts when ICE was spotted nearby
- Documented federal vehicles and agent behavior on video
- Kept each other informed — neighbor to neighbor

They Responded with Love

- De-escalated tense situations with calm presence
- Provided first aid to the injured
- Connected neighbors with lawyers and legal support

One older suburban woman says she doesn't even call it political. Her word for it: humanist.

How South Koreans Stopped Martial Law

December 3, 2024 — 10:30pm: President Yoon Suk-yeol declared martial law, suspending the constitution and deploying soldiers to the National Assembly. By 4:30am, it was over.

What Happened

Citizens flooded the streets. Within hours, thousands surrounded the National Assembly — unarmed, peaceful, and unmovable.

Assembly members pushed through. Lawmakers physically forced their way into the building past soldiers to cast the votes that overturned the decree.

Soldiers stood down. Faced with massive peaceful resistance, the military refused to carry out orders against their own people.

How They Did It

They were organized before the crisis. Networks, signal groups, and protest muscle memory were already in place. They didn't need to start from scratch.

They moved immediately. The first hour matters most. Citizens didn't wait for permission or a leader — they showed up.

They stayed nonviolent. No weapons. No riots. The moral clarity of nonviolent resistance made the government's position untenable.

What It Means for Us

This is not theoretical. It happened in a modern constitutional republic with a functioning military. It happened fast. It was stopped by citizens.

Six hours. That is the window. Preparation, networks, and willingness to act — built before the crisis — made the difference.

We can do this. Not because it will be easy, but because people like us have done it before. The template exists.

South Korean people stopped it in six hours. We can too.

The Disney Boycott Worked

1.7 million participants. When Disney suspended Jimmy Kimmel under political pressure, organized citizens launched a boycott — and Disney reversed course in days.

What Happened	How They Did It	What It Means for Us
Disney suspended Jimmy Kimmel under political pressure. 1.7 million people responded immediately.	Cancel Disney+. Skip the films. Avoid the parks. No central org, no leader — just one clear ask that spread organically.	Corporations run on subscriptions and goodwill. Organized economic pressure changes the math — fast.
Disney reversed course within days. Kimmel hosted the Oscars. The boycott stopped.	The ask was specific and nonpartisan — one reversible decision, not a crusade. Disciplined message, disciplined exit.	Pick a specific, winnable target. Make one ask. Apply pressure. Exit when you win. This is Gene Sharp's method in action.

Economic non-cooperation works — when we're organized.

Resistance Tools That We Can Use

Gene Sharp — Recommended Reading: From Dictatorship to Democracy & Waging Nonviolent Struggle. *Used by organizers in Serbia, Burma, Iran, and Ukraine.*

Political Noncooperation

- Refuse to participate in administration-aligned events
- Boycott complicit institutions and their sponsors
- Delay and slow-walk unjust orders at every level

Economic Pressure

- General strikes and coordinated work stoppages
- Boycott businesses enabling harm
- Divest from complicit financial institutions

Social Resistance

- Build neighborhood networks and mutual aid systems
- Public accountability for collaborators
- Build parallel community structures that function independently

If a Clear Crisis Is Triggered

We need to be prepared for emergency situations when there is a clear power grab, a constitutional crisis.

1. **A crisis is declared — real or manufactured.** A terrorist attack, a market collapse, mass unrest. The facts don't matter yet. The emergency does. Emergency powers are invoked before anyone can verify the trigger.

2. **Civil liberties are suspended 'temporarily.'** Arrests without warrant. Press access restricted. Protest criminalized. Each step is framed as necessary, limited, and short-term. None of it is walked back.

3. **Elections are delayed or delegitimized.** Opposition is labeled a threat to national security. Ballots are called fraudulent before they're counted. Courts are bypassed. 'We'll return to normal when it's safe.'

4. **When courts are defied.** When the executive branch refuses to comply with a clear, final court order — not appealing it, not clarifying it, just ignoring it — that’s the line.

The First Hour of the Crisis

The first hour matters the most. Authoritarian seizures depend on confusion, shock, and the appearance of inevitability. Your job is to deny them that. Act visibly, calmly, and immediately.

1. **Don't freeze. Verify first.** Take 5 minutes to confirm what you're seeing — check at least three independent sources. Do not share unverified information. Then act. Paralysis is the enemy; so is panic. Calm, informed action is your first task.

2. **Open Signal and alert your network.** Send a brief, factual message to your Signal group: what you know, what you don't, and that you're watching. Ask people to do the same with their networks. Information that moves fast and accurately is the first line of resistance.

3. **Call or text your elected officials — right now.** Find your U.S. House rep and both senators. Call their offices. Leave a message. Text their public lines. Say: 'I am watching. I expect you to publicly affirm the Constitution and reject any suspension of democratic process.' Make them go on record.

4. **Get outside. Peacefully, visibly, immediately.** Go to the nearest public square, courthouse steps, or busy corner. Bring a sign or nothing at all. A visible, peaceful public presence in the first hour signals that people are not accepting this quietly. It is one of the most important things you can do.

5. **Document everything you see.** Take video and photos of public spaces, police presence, official vehicles, and any unusual activity. Backup to cloud immediately. Do not confront — observe and record. What gets documented gets preserved. What gets preserved can be used.

The First 24 Hours of the Crisis

The seizure will try to normalize itself overnight. Your job in the first 24 hours is to prevent that — to keep the pressure public, organized, and unmistakably nonviolent.

1. **Organize a public gathering — within hours, not days.** Use your existing Signal group and neighborhood networks to call people together at a public location. It doesn't need to be a march. A visible, peaceful, large gathering in a public square says: we are here, we are watching, and we are not afraid.

2. **Demand independent verification of the triggering event.** Every authoritarian seizure uses a crisis as justification. Demand to know: who verified the threat? What independent evidence exists? Push elected officials, journalists, and civil liberties organizations to investigate the premise of the emergency before accepting it.

3. **Connect with organized resistance — don't go it alone.** Contact your local Indivisible chapter, ACLU affiliate, union, or faith community. Organized, coordinated resistance is exponentially more powerful than individual action. Find out what's being planned. Show up. Bring others.

4. **Support economic non-cooperation if called.** General strikes, work stoppages, and consumer boycotts are among the most powerful nonviolent tools available. If labor organizations, civil society groups, or coordinated campaigns call for economic non-cooperation — support it. Economies cannot run without people.

5. **Check on the most vulnerable people in your circle.** Undocumented neighbors. Activists. Public figures. Journalists. People who were already being targeted before the crisis. Reach out. Offer shelter, resources, legal contacts, and presence. Protecting the most vulnerable is not a side task — it is the work.

Message Discipline During a Crisis

When everyone says the same thing, it gets heard.

SAMPLE: We the People reject the attempt by the federal government to interfere in our election. This is unconstitutional and must be stopped. We will not stand for it.

Social Media	To the Media	To Your Representatives
X / Facebook / Instagram/ tiktok / Bluesky / YouTube	Send to local media	Call your federal, state, and local reps
We the People reject federal interference in our election. This is unconstitutional. We will not stand for it. *#ShowUp2Defend #DefendTheConstitution #PatrioticAct*	*"We the People reject the attempt by the federal government to interfere in our election. This is unconstitutional and must be stopped. We will not stand for it."* *— Community members across [your region], [date]*	*"I am a constituent. I reject federal interference in our election. I expect you to publicly affirm the Constitution and reject any suspension of democratic process. Your silence is not acceptable."*

Tool for contacting our representatives: commoncause.org/find-your-representative

Create a Crisis Plan

Cultivate an active and prepared mindset so that when the emergency comes, we are already in motion.

Run Drills.

Drills make action automatic. When a crisis hits, there is no time to figure things out.

The Martial Law Drill. It's 10pm. Martial law has just been declared. What does each person do in the next hour?

The Election Is Stolen Drill. The voting machines have been confiscated by the federal government. What do we do?

Prepare Your Message.

Decide now what you will say — and how you will say it together.

Agree on two or three core phrases. Simple, clear, repeatable. 'We are nonviolent and we are not going away.' Practice saying them.

Know what you will not say. Inflammatory language, unverified claims, anything that sounds like a threat. Message discipline means knowing the line and holding it.

Build the Network.

Mass turnout happens because conversations took place before the crisis.

Talk to your people before anything happens. Tell your neighbors, your coworkers, your family: here is what I'm prepared to do. Here is where I'll be.

Talk to your representatives. Explain the plan and ask them to plan on being there to join their constituents and make a statement.

The practice of creating a plan will set in motion the grassroots local organizing and building up people power.

From a Crisis Plan to Building a Network

Use this powerpoint to get the conversation started and build an organized local network

Week 1-2: Show Up

- Connect with your local Indivisible or No Kings chapter.
- Host a small gathering to go over this deck. A potluck is a good setup
- Ask people to organize their own meetings to review the powerpoint.
- Sign up for Signal and start a neighborhood group text.

Week 2-4: Organize

- Map your community's assets: medical training, legal knowledge, language skills, etc.
- Agree on an emergency communication protocol — who texts whom, in what order.
- Run one or more tabletop drills.
- Organize a half-day nonviolent resistance training.

Month 2+: Build Power

- Create a resistance plan for the long haul. Study Gene Sharp.
- Recruit people to take on specific ongoing roles — not just show up.
- Organize trainings for people to learn the skills to do outreach beyond the existing network. For example, deep canvassing and cultural translation.

Ultimately, we are building an organized local network to empower the people whether we are in a crisis or a stable democracy.

Participation Builds Power

Organized local networks make traditional participation even more powerful.

1. **Vote in every election — especially 2026.** The 2026 midterms may be the most important election of our lifetimes. Local races — school boards, city councils, state legislators, sheriffs — determine who enforces laws and who protects rights.

2. **Call, write, and show up. Relentlessly.** Elected officials respond to constituent pressure — especially persistent, organized pressure. Call both senators and your House rep every week. Show up to town halls. Bring others. Make them go on record. Silence from a representative is a choice — name it publicly.

3. **Set a goal for improving turnout especially among young voters and naturalized citizens.** Local offices are often won with 200 votes. We can become kingmakers for every election, especially local ones.

Imagine our country if we had over 80% voter turnout in every election. It would change our country.

Engaging in Difficult Conversations

Organizing requires some challenging conversations with people who don't always agree with you.

Your first word is your breath. Before responding to anything charged, breathe first. It resets your nervous system and buys you the moment to respond instead of react.

Mirror, don't argue. Repeat the last few words they said, calmly. People open up when they feel heard — not challenged.

Label the emotion. "It sounds like you're frustrated." Naming what someone feels defuses defensiveness and builds trust fast.

Listen for values, not positions. People share bedrock concerns: family, safety, fairness, dignity. Start there — not with ideology — and you'll find more common ground than you expect.

Ask How and What, not Why. "How did you come to see it that way?" Why puts people on the defensive. How and What invite reflection.

Name the dynamic, not the person. Instead of "You're being aggressive," try "I notice this conversation is getting heated." Keeps the door open.

Aim for 'That's right,' not 'You're right.' When they say "that's right" — they feel genuinely understood. That's the turning point.

Connect, not conquer. A conversation you win but a relationship you lose is not a victory. Ask: "Help me understand what matters most to you here."

Translation, not conversion. You don't need to change someone's worldview to find common ground. Help them see how your concern honors values they already hold.

Contempt closes doors. Curiosity opens them. Writing off potential allies based on how they voted guarantees the coalition stays small. Get genuinely curious about what people value.

You rarely change minds by arguing. You change minds by making people feel genuinely heard.

Tell Your Own Story

Authoritarians weaponize dehumanization. Telling our own story is how we maintain our humanity and reclaim our power.

Why It Matters

Stories humanize. Every authoritarian movement depends on stripping people of their humanity — reducing them to threats or abstractions. Your story, told in your own voice, is a direct act of resistance against that.

Documentation is how ordinary people become history. When ordinary people tell their own stories, that IS the historical record. Your meetings, your decisions, your community are worth preserving.

What Empowerment Looks Like

Someone writes a short reflection after every meeting. Not a press release — just a few honest sentences about what happened, who showed up, and what shifted.

Someone takes photos. Someone keeps a record. The story of your community showing up IS the movement.

This is a story war. If we don't tell our own story, it will be misrepresented by our opponents.

We humanize with stories. That is essential to both resistance and democratic governance.

Protect Your Community: Digital Security

Good digital security protects your community so you can keep doing the work.

Tools

Signal

End-to-end encrypted messaging and calls. Open source, free, used by journalists and activists worldwide.

ProtonMail

Encrypted email based in Switzerland. Better than Gmail for sensitive messages.

Habits That Matter

Use disappearing messages: In Signal, set messages to auto-delete after 1 week.

Don't plan sensitive actions in writing: For anything sensitive, talk in person or by voice.

Protect Your Network with Vetting:. Don't give someone full network access right away. Build trust.

Know your rights: You may remain silent. Disable biometrics (face/fingerprint) — use a passcode. You don't have to unlock your phone. Call a lawyer before speaking to federal agents.

Principles of the Movement

These values and principles will hold the movement together

Strictly Nonviolent

Violence is both a moral failure and a strategic gift to those in power. It gives them a pretext, discredits everything, and loses the people we need most.

Politically Inclusive

Not owned by any party, faction, or ideology. No strident language that repels ordinary people. Anyone who loves their neighbors belongs here.

Democratic & Patriotic

Rooted in the American tradition of defending the Constitution. The flag belongs to everyone. Draw on shared values — not partisan identity.

Extraordinarily Ordinary

Must attract your TV-watching mom, your apolitical neighbor, the local grocer, the Uber driver, the retiree down the street.

Loneliness, Love, and Community

Mass loneliness is the precondition for totalitarianism. — Hannah Arendt, The Origins of Totalitarianism

Loneliness Is Our Vulnerability	Love Is Our Strength
Loneliness is not just being alone — it is the loss of a shared world. When neighbors don't know each other and civic life hollows out, people become easy to manipulate. Authoritarians do not just exploit loneliness. They manufactures it.	In Minneapolis, neighbors who barely knew each other's names brought food, walked children to school, stood watch through the night. That is love for humanity and community. **The story of this movement, in the end, will be a story about love** — love for our neighbors, love for the world, love of freedom.

Loneliness is the cancer destroying democracy. Love, joy, and community are the cure.

Start with one conversation.

This deck was created for you to build a powerful local network with citizens ready to take action. Share it. Use it.

showup2defend.com

This movement begins at kitchen tables, in parking lots, and on front porches — one conversation at a time.